

Credit - Drishti Ias

India-Belgium Relations



For Prelims: National Investment and Infrastructure Fund , UN Security Council , India-EU Free Trade Agreement , BBNJ Agreement , NATO , India-BLEU Joint Economic Commission

For Mains: India-Belgium bilateral relations, India-EU relations and Belgium's role as a gateway to European institutions, India's engagement with European strategic and security frameworks

Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Belgian Prime Minister's **September 2026 visit to India** strengthened bilateral ties through the **India-Belgium Joint Statement** , the **Investment Fast-Track Mechanism** , and **defence cooperation agreements** .



Summary

- India-Belgium relations are expanding beyond traditional diamond trade into defence, semiconductors, critical minerals, green hydrogen, investment and deep technology, with Belgium also serving as an important gateway to EU institutions.
- The partnership is supported by mechanisms such as the India-BLEU Joint Economic Commission, the Investment Fast-Track Mechanism and growing cooperation in defence co-development, green transition and India-EU engagement.

What are the Key Outcomes of the Belgian Prime Minister's Visit to India?

- **Defence and Security Cooperation:** Belgium, a Western European country, and India are strengthening defence and security ties through regular military exchanges, staff talks and defence-industrial cooperation. Belgium has also assured **India that it will not supply defence equipment or military technology to Pakistan**.
 - Maritime cooperation is expanding with the planned deployment of the Belgian frigate **LEOPOLD I to India in November 2026** . Both nations also appointed resident Defence Attachés.
 - India and Belgium signed a Defence Framework Agreement, along with an MoU between the **Belgian Security and Defence Industry (BDSI) and the Society of Indian Defence Manufacturers (SIDM)**, supported by private-sector agreements.
 - Cooperation will cover weapon systems, ammunition, radar, electro-optical sensors, command-and-control and counter-drone systems, leveraging Belgium's defence expertise.
 - Cooperation in **counter-terrorism, transnational organised crime and cybercrime** is also being enhanced through a **Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Federal Police of Belgium MoU** and discussions on a **Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism** .
- **Economic, Investment and Technology Cooperation:** India and Belgium launched an **Investment Fast-Track Mechanism** to address investment bottlenecks and facilitate two-way investments.
 - Both countries are **looking to formalise collaboration between Belgium's Federal Holding and Investment Company (SFPIM) and India's National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF)** to help establish an **Indo-Belgian Economic and Investment Corridor** .
 - **India-Belgium bilateral trade reached USD 13.01 billion in 2025-26** , with both countries targeting a **doubling of trade over the next five years** and diversification beyond the traditional **diamond trade** (Antwerp-Surat/Mumbai) into **critical minerals, life sciences and nuclear energy** .
 - Belgium seeks to position the **Port of Antwerp-Bruges** as a critical logistics gateway for **Indian exports to Europe** , while expanding cooperation in green hydrogen, maritime services and infrastructure.
- **Multilateral and Global Governance:** Both nations agreed to support each other's bids for **non-permanent membership of the UN Security Council** (India for 2028-29; Belgium for 2037-38). Belgium reaffirmed support for India's permanent membership.
 - Both leaders welcomed the conclusion of negotiations for the **India-EU Free Trade Agreement (2026)** and endorsed the **Joint India-EU Comprehensive Strategic Agenda for 2030**.

- **Science, Space, and Green Transition:** Acknowledged the contributions of the **Belgo-Indian Network for Astronomy and Astrophysics (BINA)** and Belgian components in India's landmark facilities (**Devasthal Optical Telescope, Multi-Application Solar Telescope**).
 - They also renewed cooperation on **green hydrogen** , **offshore wind and energy storage** , while supporting the **BBNJ Agreement** for conservation of marine biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction.

What is the Strategic Significance of India-Belgium Relations?

- **Gateway to Europe:** Belgium hosts the headquarters of the **European Union (EU)** and **NATO** , making deeper ties with Brussels strategically important for India's **engagement with European institutions and security frameworks** .
- **Semiconductor and Deep Tech Ecosystems:** Belgium houses **Interuniversity Microelectronics Centre (IMEC)** , a world-leading independent research hub in **nanoelectronics and digital technologies** .
 - Integrating imec with **India's semiconductor mission** (e.g., ChipIn Centre, **C-DAC**) is pivotal for reducing India's import dependencies and building an indigenous, shock-proof microelectronics supply chain.
- **Green Transition Capacity Building:** Belgium's advanced capabilities in clean technology directly complement **India's climate commitments**.
 - Collaborations spanning **green hydrogen (between GH2 India and the Belgian Hydrogen Council)**, energy storage, and offshore wind infrastructure are essential for meeting India's decarbonization targets.
- **Strategic Counterweight to China:** Belgium sees **India as a stabilising power and a strategic counterweight to China in South Asia** and the Indian Ocean, while its defence-industrial expertise can support India's military modernisation, enhancing India's strategic capacity and resilience in countering China.
- **Boost to Aatmanirbhar Bharat:** The shift from a buyer-seller dynamic to co-development and technology transfer aligns with India's **"Make in India" initiative**. Belgium seeks to embed its industries deeply within India's military-industrial ecosystem.

India-Belgium Relations

- **Diplomatic Relations:** Belgium was among the first European countries to establish diplomatic relations with independent India in **1947** , with ties rooted in **rule of law, federalism and pluralism** .
- **Economic Relations:** The **India-BLEU Joint Economic Commission (JCM)** , established in **1997** , is the main institutional mechanism for bilateral economic cooperation. **Diamonds, precious stones, chemicals and machinery** have traditionally dominated trade.
- **Science & Technology:** Cooperation covers **space technology, astronomy, nuclear research, ICT and renewable energy** , including collaboration on the **Devasthal Optical Telescope in Uttarakhand, developed with Belgian optics** .
- **Education & Culture:** Academic partnerships exist between Indian and Belgian universities, while the **1973 Cultural Agreement** provides the foundation for cultural exchanges.
- **Historical Linkages:** Over **9,000 Indian soldiers** sacrificed their lives in **Flanders Fields during World War I** . An **Indian Memorial Pillar** was installed near the **Menin Gate in Ypres in 2011** to honour their sacrifice.
- **Diaspora and Mobility:** Belgium hosts over 24,000 Indians, primarily IT professionals and students. Recognizing the need for skilled workforce movement, the two sides are prioritizing the conclusion of a Migration and Mobility Agreement to facilitate seamless talent exchange.

What are the Key Challenges in India-Belgium Relations and the Way Forward?

Strategic Dimension	Key Challenge	Way Forward
Trade & GVCs	Heavy dependence on the diamond trade creates supply-chain vulnerability and exposes Indian MSMEs to evolving traceability requirements.	Diversify trade into Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs) , green engineering and avionics , while pursuing mutually recognised certification standards.
Climate & EU Regulations	CBAM and European Union Deforestation Regulation (EUDR) may increase compliance costs for Indian exports and act as non-tariff barriers.	Pursue regulatory equivalence, carbon-accounting cooperation and transition support through the India-EU TTC .
Defence & Technology Transfer	IP restrictions and EU dual-use controls can limit cooperation to licence manufacturing rather than genuine co-development.	Use iDEX and joint ventures to promote co-development, technology transfer and faster End-User Certificate clearances.
Investment & Capital	Weak dispute-resolution mechanisms and the investment protection gap can discourage Belgian institutional investment.	Operationalize the SFPIM-NIIF corridor and channel patient capital into green hydrogen, offshore wind and infrastructure .
Semiconductors & Deep Tech	Cooperation with Belgium's IMEC risks remaining focused on research rather than commercialisation.	Develop commercial fab alliances, joint IP ownership and co-funded R&D in chip design and advanced packaging.

Conclusion

India-Belgium ties are expanding toward **deep-tech, defence co-production and green-transition cooperation** . Belgium’s role as an **EU institutional hub** gives India strategic leverage in shaping broader India-EU engagement. Strengthening **patient capital and joint technology development** can build long-term geoeconomic resilience.

Drishti Mains Question:

India's bilateral partnerships with European countries can complement rather than substitute its broader engagement with the European Union. Discuss in the context of India-Belgium relations.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What was the Investment Fast-Track Mechanism launched by India and Belgium?

It aims to **remove investment bottlenecks and facilitate two-way investments** , including through the proposed **SFPIM-NIIF economic and investment corridor** .

2. Why is Belgium strategically important for India?

Belgium hosts the headquarters of the **EU and NATO** , making it an important partner for India's engagement with European economic, institutional and security frameworks.

3. What are the major emerging areas of India-Belgium economic cooperation?

The relationship is expanding beyond **diamonds** into **critical minerals, life sciences, nuclear energy, green engineering, semiconductors and deep technology** .

4. How can Belgium contribute to India's semiconductor ambitions?

Cooperation with Belgium's **imec** , a leading nanoelectronics research hub, can support India's semiconductor ecosystem through **chip design, advanced packaging, joint R&D and commercialisation** .

5. What are the major challenges in India-Belgium relations?

Key challenges include **diamond-trade dependence, CBAM/EUDR compliance costs, technology-transfer restrictions, investment-protection gaps and limited commercialisation of deep-tech research** .

[Watch Video on YouTube:

► <https://www.youtube.com/embed/Odve5-hcGQg>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: (2023)

The 'Stability and Growth Pact' of the European Union is a treaty that

1. limits the levels of the budgetary deficit of the countries of the European Union
2. makes the countries of the European Union to share their infrastructure facilities
3. enables the countries of the European Union to share their technologies

How many of the above statements are correct

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Ans: (a)

Q. The term 'Digital Single Market Strategy' seen in the news refers to (2017)

- (a) ASEAN
- (b) BRICS
- (c) EU
- (d) G20

Ans:(c)

Q. 'European Stability Mechanism', sometimes seen in the news is an (2016)

- (a) agency created by EU to deal with the impact of millions of refugees arriving from Middle East
- (b) agency of EU that provides financial assistance to eurozone countries
- (c) agency of EU to deal with all the bilateral and multilateral agreements on trade
- (d) agency of EU to deal with the conflicts arising among the member countries

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. The expansion and strengthening of NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well for India.' What is your opinion about this statement? Give reasons and examples to support your answer.
(2023)

Parliamentary Standing Committee on Healthcare Coverage Gap



Source: TH

Why in News?

The **Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare** presented its report titled '**Affordability and Accessibility of Healthcare Facilities in Public and Private Sector**' to Parliament.

- The report flagged that over **40 crore Indians** are trapped in a **healthcare gap**. This demographic, often termed the '**missing middle**', is covered neither by government health subsidies nor by private **health insurance**.

What are the Key Findings of the Parliamentary Standing Committee Report on Healthcare Affordability?

- **The 40-Crore 'Missing Middle' Coverage Gap:** Over a quarter of India's population (more than 40 crore individuals) is excluded from financial risk protection.
 - They sit just above the **poverty line**, rendering them ineligible for government-subsidized schemes like **Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY**, yet lack the income required to afford commercial health insurance.
- **Over-Reliance on the Private Sector:** The private sector accounts for more than **60% of inpatient care** and **70% of outpatient care**, leaving households without health safety nets fully exposed to commercial pricing.
 - The primary financial risk this group faces is not necessarily a single catastrophic hospital admission, but rather the **slow, steady erosion of household income** through recurring outpatient costs (medicines, consultations, and diagnostic tests).
- **Escalating Non-Communicable Disease (NCD) Burden:** The rising prevalence of chronic conditions like **diabetes, hypertension, and cardiovascular diseases** has converted outpatient care and medication into an unavoidable, lifelong recurring expense.
- **Stark Public-Private Cost Disparities:** Out-of-pocket expenditure (OOPE) differs sharply across sectors; for instance, the average cost of childbirth in private hospitals (**Rs 37,630**) is more than 16 times higher than in public facilities (**Rs 2,299**).
- **High Outlay on Pharmaceuticals:** Medicines constitute nearly **30% of India's current health expenditure**. This is exacerbated by retail pharmacy distortions, such as unregulated trade margins and over-the-counter antibiotic sales without prescriptions.
- **Underfunding in Public Health:** Government health spending stands at **1.43% of GDP**, significantly below the **National Health Policy 2017 commitment to progressively raise public health expenditure to 2.5% of GDP by 2025**.
 - Furthermore, health expenditure as a share of total government spending dropped from **6.12% in**

2021-22 to 4.89% in 2022-23 (below the pre-pandemic level of 5.02% in 2019-20).

- **Limitations of Insurance-Centric Models:** Insurance instruments alone fail to address this gap because private policies enforce high premiums, extensive waiting periods, co-payments, and disease exclusions, while disproportionately prioritizing secondary and tertiary hospitalization over primary and outpatient care.

Universal Health Coverage (UHC)

- **Universal Health Coverage (UHC)** ensures that everyone has access to **quality essential healthcare services without financial hardship**, covering promotion, prevention, treatment, rehabilitation and palliative care.
- **Status of the Health Coverage & Insurance in India:** The **Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY)** anchors coverage for the bottom 40% of the population.
 - Following a 2024 expansion, coverage now extends to all citizens aged 70 and above (Ayushman Bharat Vay Vandana) regardless of income, driving the **issuance of over 45.5 crore Ayushman Cards** by August 2026.
- **India's Foundational Health Insurance and Coverage Initiatives:**
 - **Ayushman Vaya Vandana**
 - **Employees' State Insurance Scheme (ESIS)**
 - **Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS).**
 - **National Health Mission**
 - **PM-Bharatiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana**

What are the Key Recommendations of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Healthcare Affordability?

- **Prioritize Public Capacity Over Insurance:** The committee strongly argued for building **public healthcare capacity directly**, rather than relying excessively on insurance models to purchase care from private providers.
 - It noted that there is an urgent need to regulate the prices of procedures and treatments in private hospitals to prevent the exploitation of the uninsured '**missing middle**'.
- **Promoting Generic Medicines:** The panel recommended mandating drug prescriptions by their **generic names**.
 - Furthermore, the public system should stock the **full essential drug list** at every facility so that it becomes the primary, affordable outlet for patients.
 - The report flagged excessive trade margins on medicines and the non-prescription sale of antibiotics, recommending stronger audits and enforcement.
- **Establishing a Public Health Management Cadre:** To optimize public hospital operations, the committee suggested creating a **dedicated management cadre so that clinical specialists** are not consumed by administrative duties.

- **Nationwide Enforcement of the Clinical Establishments Act:** Universal implementation of the **Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010** must be pursued to mandate standard treatment protocols, quality standards, and enforceable price transparency across private hospitals.
- **Outpatient-Centric Protection Frameworks:** National health financing models must evolve beyond secondary and tertiary hospitalizations to incorporate **outpatient care, diagnostic subsidies, and chronic disease management**, preventing households from falling into poverty through the everyday costs of staying healthy.

Conclusion

India's **Universal Health Coverage** requires more than hospitalisation insurance. **Standardising healthcare costs through the Clinical Establishments Act** and expanding **primary healthcare and outpatient services** are key to protecting the **missing middle** from medical impoverishment.

Drishti Mains Question:

"India's healthcare challenge is increasingly one of financial protection rather than merely physical access." Examine in the context of the 'missing middle'.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Who are the 'missing middle' in India's healthcare system?

They are people who are **above the eligibility threshold for government subsidies but lack adequate private health insurance**, leaving them vulnerable to healthcare expenditure.

2. What is the major limitation of insurance-centric healthcare models?

Most schemes focus on **secondary and tertiary hospitalisation**, while outpatient care, medicines and diagnostics remain inadequately covered.

3. What is the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010?

It provides a framework for **registration and regulation of clinical establishments**, including standards for treatment, quality and price transparency.

4. Why are generic medicines important for healthcare affordability?

Prescribing and promoting **generic medicines** can reduce pharmaceutical expenditure and improve access to essential drugs.

5. What is the key policy approach suggested for Universal Health Coverage?

India needs stronger **public healthcare capacity, outpatient and primary-care coverage, affordable medicines, private-sector regulation and better health financing** rather than relying only on hospitalisation insurance.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/QSUI94q26Zw>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following are the objectives of ‘National Nutrition Mission’? (2017)

1. To create awareness relating to malnutrition among pregnant women and lactating mothers.
2. To reduce the incidence of anaemia among young children, adolescent girls and women.
3. To promote the consumption of millets, coarse cereals and unpolished rice.
4. To promote the consumption of poultry eggs.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1, 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 4 only
- (d) 3 and 4 only

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. “Besides being a moral imperative of a Welfare State, primary health structure is a necessary precondition for sustainable development.” Analyse. (2021)

WMO El Niño Outlook



Source: TH

The **World Meteorological Organization (WMO)** has warned that the ongoing **El Niño phenomenon**, driven by **exceptionally warm Pacific Ocean temperatures**, is expected to intensify into a **very strong event** in the coming months and may persist until early 2027.

- **About El Niño:** El Niño is a **naturally occurring climate phenomenon** involving the **abnormal warming of sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean**. It occurs due to **changes in ocean-atmosphere interactions, including weakening trade winds**, and typically occurs every 2–7 years. It influences global wind patterns, atmospheric pressure and rainfall distribution.
- **Current El Niño Event:** The ongoing El Niño is projected to attain the **“very strong” category, the**

highest level in WMO's classification , with Pacific Ocean temperatures exceeding **2°C above normal** .

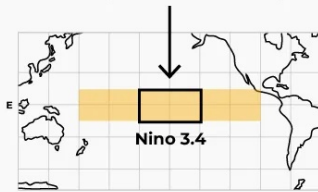
- **Global Impacts:** A strong El Niño can disrupt global climate patterns by increasing the risk of **droughts, floods, storms and typhoons** . It can also affect agriculture, food security, water availability and energy systems due to rainfall variability.
- **Impact on Global Temperatures:** Ocean heat is released gradually into the atmosphere, which can contribute to higher global temperatures in the year following an El Niño event. The strong 2023–24 El Niño contributed to **2024 becoming the warmest year on record** , and the WMO has warned that future temperature records may be challenged.
- **Implications for India:** El Niño can influence the **Indian summer monsoon** , with strong events often associated with increased probability of below-normal rainfall, though the relationship is not uniform every year. It can affect **agricultural output, irrigation availability, rural livelihoods and food prices** , highlighting the need for climate-resilient farming and efficient water management.
- **Preparedness Measures:** The WMO has emphasised strengthening **early warning systems, climate forecasting and disaster preparedness** . Measures such as promoting **drought-resistant crops, improving water management and providing climate information to agriculture, health and energy sectors** can reduce associated risks.

What is El Nino?

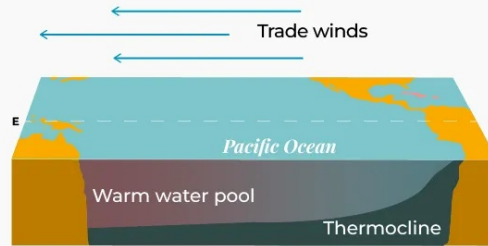
El Nino and La Nina are opposite climate phases disrupting Pacific Ocean temperatures, significantly altering global weather patterns, rainfall and ecosystems.

Neutral phase

El Nino-Southern Oscillation (ENSO)
weather patterns develops here

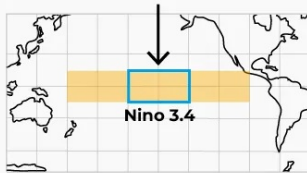


During normal conditions or ENSO's neutral phase, trade winds blow west along the equator, taking warm water from South America towards Asia and Australia.

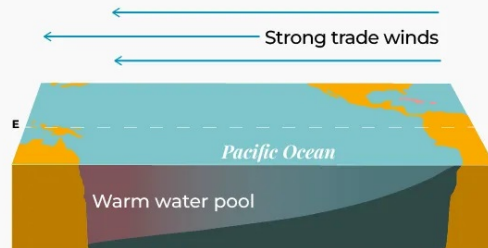


La Nina - the cool phase

0.5°C colder than average
temperatures here

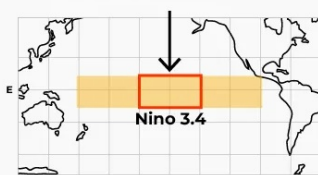


Trade winds are stronger than usual, pushing more warm water toward Asia.

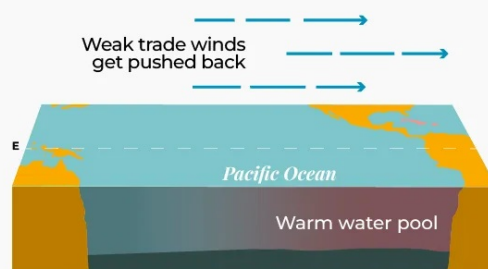


El Nino - the warm phase

0.5°C hotter than average
temperatures here



Trade winds weaken and start blowing towards the east. Warm water is pushed back towards South America.



Birth Anniversary of Dr. Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan



Source: FP

Dr. Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan's birth anniversary on 5th September has been observed as **Teachers' Day in India since 1962** to recognise the contribution of teachers and their role in shaping society.

Dr. Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan

- **About:** Dr. Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan was born on **5th September 1888** in **Tiruttani, present-day Tamil Nadu** . He completed his education at **Christian College, Madras** , and developed a deep interest in philosophy and comparative religion.
- **Academic Career:** He served as a professor at prestigious institutions, including the **University of Mysore** and the **University of Calcutta** . He later became the **first Indian to hold the Spalding Professorship of Eastern Religions and Ethics at the University of Oxford** , reflecting his global recognition as a scholar of philosophy and religion.
- **Contribution to Philosophy:** Through his writings on **Indian philosophy, comparative religion and Hindu thought** , Radhakrishnan played an important role in introducing Indian philosophical traditions to the Western world. His notable works include **Indian Philosophy and The Hindu View of Life**.
- **Role in Education:** He believed that education was a powerful tool for social transformation and emphasised the role of teachers in shaping the intellectual and moral foundation of society. He also chaired the **University Education Commission (1948-49)**, which recommended reforms for improving higher education in independent India.
- **Political Career:** He served as **India's Ambassador to the Soviet Union (1949-1952)** and became the **first Vice President of India (1952-1962)** . He later served as the **second President of India from 13th May 1962 to 13th May 1967** .
 - As President, he was known for his wisdom, scholarship, dignity of office and commitment to parliamentary democracy and constitutional values.
- **Legacy:** For his contribution to the country, he was awarded the **Bharat Ratna** , India's highest civilian honour, in 1954. He passed away on 17th April 1975, leaving behind a lasting legacy in education, philosophy and public life.

DR S RADHAKRISHNAN

(05-09-1888 - 17-04-1975)

5th September: Teachers Day; A Tribute to his contributions to Education and Philosophy.

Contribution Towards Indian Education

- 4th Vice-Chancellor of Banaras Hindu University (1939-1948)
- Elected as the Chairman of UNESCO's executive board (1948)
- Chairman of University Education Commission (1949)

At National and Global Level

- Ambassador of India to the USSR (1949-1952)
- First Vice-President of India (1952-1962)
- Second President of India (1962-1967)

Awards and Recognition

- Knighthood in 1931
- Bharat Ratna in 1954
- Honorary membership of British Royal Order of Merit in 1963
- Templeton Prize in 1975 (for vital contributions in bridging the understanding between cultures and religions of the Eastern and Western hemispheres)

Notable Works

- Indian Philosophy (1923-27)
- The Philosophy of the Upanishads (1924)
- Eastern Religions and Western Thought (1939)



Drishti IAS

Read More: [Teachers' Day 2024](#)

Birth Anniversary of V. O. Chidambaram Pillai



Source: TOI

Recently, the birth anniversary of Vallinayagam Olaganathan Chidambaram Pillai (V.O.C.) was observed on 5th September . He was a renowned lawyer, Tamil scholar, entrepreneur and one of the prominent leaders of the Swadeshi Movement in Tamil Nadu.

O. Chidambaram Pillai

- Early Life and Education:** Vallinayagam Olaganathan Chidambaram Pillai (VOC) was born on 5 September 1872 in Ottapidaram, Tirunelveli district (Tamil Nadu) . He later became a lawyer and developed an interest in social issues and public affairs.
- Entry into National Movement:** VOC entered active politics after the Partition of Bengal in 1905 and became closely associated with the Swadeshi Movement inspired by leaders like Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Lala Lajpat Rai .
- Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company:** In 1906, VOC established the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company (SSNCo.) at Tuticorin to challenge the monopoly of the British India Steam Navigation Company in maritime trade. The company operated indigenous steamship services between Tuticorin and Colombo, becoming a symbol of economic nationalism and self-reliance. This earned him the title

“Kappalottiya Tamizhan” (The Tamil Helmsman) .

- **Promotion of Swadeshi Activities:** Beyond shipping, VOC promoted indigenous industries and nationalist consciousness through initiatives such as **Swadeshi Prachar Sabha, National Godown, Desabimana Sangam and Dharmasanga Nesavu Salai** . His efforts reflected the economic dimension of the freedom struggle by encouraging Indian enterprise and reducing dependence on colonial businesses.
- **Role in Labour Movement:** VOC played an important role in the **Tuticorin Coral Mills Strike (1908)** , supporting workers’ rights and becoming one of the early leaders to connect the nationalist movement with labour issues.
- **Association with National Leaders:** VOC worked closely with **Tamil nationalist leaders such as Subramania Bharati and Subramania Siva**, strengthening the Swadeshi movement in the Tirunelveli and Tuticorin regions.
- **Imprisonment and Hardships:** Due to his nationalist activities and support for labour movements, VOC was arrested by the British government in **1908** and charged with sedition. He was sentenced to **two life imprisonments (later reduced)** and subjected to harsh treatment in prison, including forced labour at the oil press, earning him the title **“Sekkizuththa Semmal.”**
- **Literary Contributions:** Apart from his political activities, VOC was a noted **Tamil scholar and writer** . His major works include **Meyyaram (1914), Meyyarivu (1915)** and his autobiography. He also contributed commentaries on classical Tamil works such as **Thirukkural** and **Tholkappiam** .
- **Legacy:** The **V.O. Chidambaranar Port Authority at Thoothukudi (Tuticorin)** has been named in his honour. V. O. Chidambaram Pillai passed away on **18th November 1936 at Tuticorin, Tamil Nadu** .



Read More: [V. O. Chidambaram Pillai](#)

Gollala Gudi Temple



Source: TH

The **Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)** officially declared the historic **Gollala Gudi Temple** in Telangana as a **Monument of National Importance** .

- **Location:** The temple is located in Palampet village, Mulugu district, Telangana. It sits just southwest of the famous **Kakatiya Rudreshwara (Ramappa) Temple** , which is a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**.
- **Historical Context:** The temple dates back to the **12 th - 13 th centuries CE** and was built during the reign of the **Kakatiya Dynasty** .
 - The **Kakatiya dynasty**, a prominent Telugu dynasty, ruled much of the eastern Deccan from the 12th to 14th centuries, with its core territory covering present-day Telangana and Andhra Pradesh and extending into parts of Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Odisha.
- **Architectural Features:**
 - **Trikutalaya Plan:** The temple follows a rare '**Trikutalaya**' **design** , meaning it consists of three separate **shrines (garbhagrihas) connected to a central, pillared hall (mandapa)**.
 - **Deities:** The central sanctum houses a **Shiva Lingam** . The external walls have intricate sculptural niches featuring images of Hindu deities.
 - **Exquisite Carvings:** The doorways and entablatures are adorned with finely **carved hamsas (swans) and intricate jali (lattice work)**.
 - **Plinth and Guardians:** It stands on an elevated, high plinth decorated with floral and animal motifs. Two detached shrines stand in front of the main temple, guarded by finely carved *dvarapalas* (door guardians).
- **Monument of National Importance:** Monuments of National Importance are designated under the **Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (AMASR) Act, 1958**.
 - These monuments fall under the direct jurisdiction of the ASI, which functions under the Ministry of Culture. A monument or site must be at least **100 years old to be considered for this status**.
 - Once notified, the **National Monuments Authority (NMA)** regulates activities around the structure typically enforcing a 100-meter "prohibited area" (no construction allowed) and a further 200-meter "regulated area."



Read more: [India's 39th World Heritage Site: Ramappa Temple](#)